A Tiny Red Plant With a Death Hug

From: Smithsonian Science-Nature Mined: 2026-11-02 3 min read

Beside lakes in Florida lives a small plant that eats insects, with bright red thread-like leaves. In August 2026 it was named its own **species**, Drosera floridana.

Plant expert Lilly Anderson-Messec first saw it in 2014 and thought it looked special, though it was first called a type of a common sundew whose closest group lived hundreds of miles away.

Noah Juve, a student at the University of Florida, wrote the paper that made it its own **species**. He and Andreas Fleischmann compared it with close cousins at over 100 places. It stood out for its color, seeds, flowers and **bloom time**.

The plant hunts in a strange way. Sticky drops work like **flypaper**. They trap small insects. Then it wraps around them and breaks them down. People call this the slow-motion death hug.

Its home is very small. It grows only on sandy lake edges in an area about 12 miles by 16 miles. It lives in only two **counties** in Florida, Washington and Bay.

Naming it matters. Such plants can stay hidden from protection work. As Juve said, "If something doesn't have a name, how can you **conserve** it?"

Word Treasure

species -- A group of plants or animals that are all the same kind.

bloom time -- The time of year when a plant's flowers open.

flypaper -- Sticky paper that traps flies.

conserve -- To protect something in nature so it does not disappear.

counties -- Areas of land inside a state, each with its own local government.

Background you need

Some plants catch insects for food instead of getting all their food from soil.

Sundews use sticky drops to trap small insects.

Scientists give each different kind of plant its own name so it can be studied and protected.

Break it down

WHO: Lilly Anderson-Messec, Noah Juve and Andreas Fleischmann, the plant experts
WHAT: They named a new sundew species, Drosera floridana
WHERE: Beside lakes in Florida
WHY: It stood out for its color, seeds, flowers and bloom time

Why it matters

Naming a new plant helps people protect it before its tiny home disappears.

Test what you remember

1. What is the new species called?

- (A) Drosera floridana
- (B) Florida
- (C) The slow-motion death hug
- (D) A common sundew

2. Who first saw the plant in 2014?

- (A) Noah Juve
- (B) Lilly Anderson-Messec
- (C) Andreas Fleischmann
- (D) A student

3. How does the plant hunt?

- (A) It blooms at a special time
- (B) It lives beside lakes
- (C) It grows bright red leaves
- (D) Sticky drops trap insects, then it wraps around them

4. Where does the plant grow?

- (A) In Central Park
- (B) At over 100 places
- (C) Sandy lake edges in Washington and Bay counties
- (D) Hundreds of miles away

5. Why does naming the plant matter?

- (A) So it can grow red leaves
- (B) So it can eat insects
- (C) So it can bloom
- (D) So it can be conserved

6. What did Juve and Fleischmann compare the plant with?

- (A) Seeds and flowers
- (B) Close cousins at over 100 places
- (C) A common sundew
- (D) Lakes in Florida

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):